Session 21

2025-09-07

1 - Lost horses

~06:30, 17 Uktar 1489 DR

1. The fight is barely over and Amidamaru opens with the one thought that will drive the morning — making the *"company of the golden fish"* pay for abandoning them. Nyx, half an eye still on the camp, slips off to read the ground for horse-tracks while the rest keep arguing. Eguzkilore reasons through it: the Company of the Boar had only two directions open to them, forward or back; had they taken the road north, they would already be ahead of the caravan and bound to be caught sooner or later — so they must have fled south, back the way everyone came.
2. The count is laid out — four horses missing: two guard mounts, two draft animals, one from a cultist-suspected merchant's wagon and another from **Beyd** the beer-trader's cart. Amidamaru checks after **Noohar** — the merchant who initially hired him — only to find out he has no escort.
3. Amidamaru turns the merchant-group himself — pulls them into a loose half-circle and makes his case: with four horses short, someone will have to drop a cart; the ones who promised to protect them have run; those still here fought and bled without a plate of food between them. Nuberroca draws his lance behind Amidamaru and declares that they will be ready if things come to it.
4. The merchants chew on it and settle: nobody drops a cart. Beyd's cart ties onto another cart and pulls with one horse; the three suspected-cultist merchants will do the same with their own cart. **Eldkin** is asked how far the troll country runs — three more days to leave it, roughly ten to the main Trade Way. Nobody is willing to peel off six horses to go hunt the four stolen ones; priority is Waterdeep.
5. Nyx returns to say the tracks go north, no older than four hours; running them down would need horses they don't have and leave the caravan unguarded. The decision stands: continue north together.

2 - New wages

1. **Lai** opens with promotions. Nyx moves from sergeant to bodyguard and Eguzkilore to sergeant; **Edhelri** takes Mialee back as bodyguard with a hefty raise, after the slight the merchant had done her. **Noohar** hires Amidamaru as bodyguard again.
2. Nuberroca stands apart. He turns to the merchant group and demands gold, flat-out, as the price for the lives he has already saved — making clear the commoner family he had been camping beside stays protected either way. The merchants mutter, pool a coin each, and come up with four pieces together; Nuberroca pockets them, says *"he hablado"*, and walks off.
3. Camp strikes — graves for the four dead soldiers, pyres for the trolls, two hours before the wagons move again.

3 - Shapes in the sky

~16:00, 17 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Afternoon on the road, Amidamaru keeps **Munin** circling high and gets back a report of four shapes a long way off, wheeling in a circle like vultures but wrong for the size. He pings Nyx with a magical whisper in her ear and sends her forward with Munin flying ahead.
2. Nyx and Munin close to the brush edge; Nyx fails to recognize the shapes, but Amidamaru is sure they are not vultures. The shapes have already spotted them and are turning in. Munin tucks into a bush ready to vanish if danger closes in; Nuberroca lets the fury take him and rushes forward through the brush.

4 - The perytons dive

1. The lead bird comes down the sky like a peregrine falcon — talons first, beak after — and takes Nyx on the way through. Only up close does the shape resolve: a parasitic predator Nyx has heard of in a dark story, something that feeds on hearts.
2. Kaelthar slips to a tree, draws a shortbow, and lays an arrow through the first bird's feathers from a long distance off. The arrow lands but the plumage soaks most of the damage.
3. Nyx pins her hunter's mark on the diving bird, using her powers to put a black-glowing arrow through its chest, leaving it staggered. Amidamaru shrugs the shield off his arm so he can weave his sword-song, draws a **Shadow Blade** out of thin air, and chops with it and his off-hand dagger. Mialee throws up a bank of fog behind Nuberroca and ducks out of sight.
4. ***[EPIC]*** Nuberroca runs headlong into the fog as if fleeing, pivots inside it, and vanishes into a jaunt that sets him well up in the air, polearm first, to spear the lead bird. He misses, drops the lance in the air and throws everything into a grapple instead, wrestling the bird mid-air by the wings as it falls. The two of them hit the bushes together — the bird takes the worst of it, Nuberroca dulls the pain through his rage. He drags it still-grappled into the fog where it can only fight blind.
5. A second peryton dives in on Nyx: beak and claws tearing at her. Amidamaru casts a spell to distract the creature, but the hit lands anyway and Nyx goes down unconscious. Her last shout to the field is that these things *need hearts*; nobody knows what for. A beat later Amidamaru throws himself bodily onto her, shell up, as cover.
6. Mialee ducks and darts to Nuberroca's shoulder in the fog, guided by sound and his own call-out. She appears to see where he can only hear and cuts the grappled bird twice with her twin scimitars. The bird is a mess of plumage but still breathing. Eguzkilore stays at range, puts two arrows into the peryton on Kaelthar's side of the field, then catches his breath and shifts into position behind the fog before the birds can retaliate.
7. Amidamaru, almost on instinct, pops one of his share of Nyx's berries between her lips — she comes around dizzy and weak. On the next swing he puts the Shadow Blade through the nearest bird with a deafening boom of thunder.

5 - A rogue griffon

1. Above the fight, over the camp's own shouting, a far larger pair of wings rolls in from the south — a gigantic griffon, muzzled and with mittens on its claws, coming down on the lead peryton in a stooping dive. The griffon can hook the bird but the muzzle keeps it from doing damage; a flurry of plumes rises off the pair.
2. ***[EPIC]*** As the griffon pulls up, a figure comes off its back — Sinsong, choosing the moment to let go — and falls through the air gracefully. A dozen feet from the ground angelic wings sprout from his shoulders and a ring of pale celestial figures spreads out around him, attacking anything within a few paces. He glides low so the ring sweeps the three birds together.
3. The celestial guardians wound two of the perytons; the three of them turn and bolt straight up, avoiding the magical creatures. Nuberroca pulls a rope from his pack and ties his grappled bird at beak and wings — down and out of the fight — then tries to grow huge again, but he is too exhausted to manage it.
4. Two of the fleeing birds catch Nyx by the shoulders and lift her into the air, bound for the sky; she twists and shakes but fails to escape.
5. Kaelthar's draconic wings beat open and he magically teleports up to reach the two carrying birds in the air — he lets fly a cone of dragon-fire that takes both perytons and the unconscious Nyx in the same arc; both birds are severely hurt but hold on.
6. ***[EPIC]*** Amidamaru pulls a diamond chip from his belt and arcs a small sphere of fire upward: it bursts on the first fleeing bird and consumes it on the spot, then jumps onto the second turning it into a ball of burning feathers. Nyx falls limp from the dying bird's grasp as the sphere bursts across her face.
7. ***[EPIC]*** Eguzkilore has one chance and throws everything into the catch — he vaults into the trajectory, getting his arms under Nyx just before she hits the ground.
8. Sinsong quickly summons a bond of magical aid on the three of them and Nyx is on her feet with an open chest but her heart untouched, the open wound partly closing under a soft red glow.
9. Nuberroca walks over to the bird he had tied, draws his lance, and puts it through the heart; then coils the rope, picks up the lance, and he is done.

6 – An unwanted pendant

1. The griffon is loose now — it works the muzzle off its beak and then tears the mittens off its claws, and once free it is nervous and will not stay still. Sinsong moves to introduce it as **Targutai**, a gift from a merchant he met on his detour; the griffon can be handled if nobody startles it.
2. With the griffon loose and nervous and Nuberroca walking straight toward it — fresh from boasting that lethal damage is necessary — Sinsong fears for the beast and speaks a word of command on him: *flee*. The barbarian dashes a long way north before his own protest can land.
3. Nuberroca turns back moments later; on the way in he sees Sinsong gesturing a second cast and holds himself ready. The cleric whispers a sleep-spell to pin him before he can retaliate; Nuberroca teleports clear of its area before the words land.
4. From that safe distance Nuberroca throws the stone Sinsong had once given him back at the dwarf's face and walks away.
5. Sinsong fills the gap of the lost days over the quiet that follows: he drifted away from the party in Baldur's Gate and didn't find them afterwards. He was lost in the city for three days, then bartered a griffon from a merchant he befriended in order to reach them again. Along the way he passed a lone cart with an unusual bird on the merchant's shoulder, a group of trolls, and some burial-mound pyres. Amidamaru reads him as hiding something but no more than Sinsong always does.

7 – A wolf called Fenrir

~21:00, 17 Uktar 1489 DR

1. The caravan beds down early. Sinsong fits the mittens and muzzle back onto Targutai, with Nuberroca helping gently when asked; they tie the griffon at a tree well away from the camp horses. Nyx, badly cut across the chest, rests for the whole time.
2. Kaelthar summons his bonded mount out of nothing in the shape of a giant wolf — **Fenrir**, wits no sharper than a regular wolf's, but fine for pulling a cart or startling anyone who comes close. Amidamaru takes first watch with Eguzkilore; Nuberroca and Mialee take second.
3. Amidamaru explains the pair of new animals to the caravan when the questions come — the griffon will be kept far from the horses and Fenrir is indeed a very docile wolf.

8 – Moving north

~08:00, 18 Uktar 1489 DR

1. The caravan rolls out at dawn. Sinsong holds the griffon under control with effort and a word of command ready if the bond slips, feeding him one of Nyx's berries to steady him before departing.
2. Along the way, Nyx finds prints that are at least a couple days old. Sinsong mounts the griffon and strikes north to scout for the stolen horses while the caravan rolls on. The road through the end of troll country is light on sign.
3. Night falls with Sinsong still in the field. He casts a *sending* spell over to Nyx — tracks of two or three horses heading north, it is dark and there is no fire. The next day he searches on and finds nothing more, then turns back; it takes him until the following night to reach the caravan.
4. At the camp reunion, Sinsong admits that the *command* and the *sleep* spells had been to keep Nuberroca off a griffon he was sure the goliath meant to kill; when he presses on Nuberroca's loyalty, Nuberroca tells him he has no more talismans worshipping any false god. Sinsong tries to return the stone as if dropped by accident; Nuberroca refuses to even look at it.
5. The remaining days run quiet — Targutai pulling with the carts, Fenrir alongside, with the caravan edging out of troll country.

9 – Broken crates

~16:30, 23 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Mid-column, Targutai turns on the draft horse harnessed next to him and takes a bite out of its neck; the horse screams, tears the harness, and bolts. The griffon snaps the lines on his side and goes after it at low altitude.
2. Sinsong, with the chaos exploding around him, throws a sleep-spell at Targutai to stop the rampage, but the griffon twists free of the weave even after Amidamaru's attempt to distract the beast. Sinsong uses his magic on Targutai again — a command of *come to me* — and the griffon only just gives in, halting in mid-chase. Nyx and Eguzkilore break off to run down the fleeing horse.
3. ***[EPIC]*** Nuberroca jaunts into the air above the suspected-cultist cart that Targutai had torn loose from, and lets himself fall into its cargo bed. Amidamaru starts coaxing the split harness back together with a word of mending as the shouting goes up around them. Before the guards wrestle Nuberroca off the wagon, he cracks one of the crates with a slam of his shoulder; the wood splits enough to show a glint of something metallic within. He plays the whole thing off with a thin apology for how clumsy he is, but no-one is convinced.
4. The suspected merchants' guards draw crossbows on him in seconds; Nuberroca stands up and tells them to fire if they have the stones. **Paco** — the one Amidamaru has always said is likeable — is the first to lower his crossbow and ask Nuberroca to keep away from their carts, promising no quarrel if the barbarian does the same. Amidamaru and Mialee together, playing to the merchants' nerves, talk the standoff down.
5. Nyx and Eguzkilore come back with the wounded horse and a bloody scrap of cloth cut from the brush where they caught it; by the time they arrive the cart is together again under Amidamaru's hands. The tortle studies the cloth and recognises it as **Khorvalis**'s; Nyx tells them that she also saw dried blood and a torn horse-hoof in the brush, and thinks the trolls got at least one of the stragglers.
6. Sinsong flies Nyx up on the griffon to search west of the road for signs of the stragglers. Meanwhile, Amidamaru uses his magical whisper to ask Nuberroca, and the barbarian replies along the same magical thread — jewels and coin in the crates. Overhead, Nyx finds Khorvalis's severed hand and his axe at a wider patch of churned ground; Sinsong *sends* the find back to Amidamaru — the pattern reads *trolls*.
7. Flying back towards the caravan, Sinsong floats breaking the carts open now. Nyx cuts him off: better to let the carts reach their stop so the party can find **Naerytar** at the end of the trail.

10 – The painted stone

~12:00, 27 Uktar 1489 DR

1. After four quiet days, during which Sinsong keeps Targutai in hand with constant supervision and the command of return held in reserve, they are finally approaching the main Trade Way road.
2. When they glimpse the intersection, they notice a large piece of stone sitting in the middle of it, painted with something they cannot make out — and they are sure it is moving.